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Experiment 7: Comparative Study of Popular No-Code and Low-Code Application Development Platforms

1. Aim

To compare popular no-code and low-code platforms for building business applications, on the basis of ease of use, customisation, integration, scalability, pricing model and the typical user.

2. Definitions

No-code platforms let users build applications entirely through visual interfaces such as drag-and-drop forms, data models and workflow designers, without writing code. Low-code platforms also provide visual development, but they additionally allow custom scripts or code where the visual tools are not enough. Both approaches shorten development time and allow non-programmers, often called citizen developers, to contribute to application building under the supervision of IT staff.

3. Criteria for Comparison

- Ease of use: how quickly a non-programmer can build a working form and workflow.
- Customisation: how far the logic and appearance can be extended beyond the visual tools.
- Integration: availability of connectors to databases, email, payment and other business systems.
- Scalability and governance: suitability for large user numbers, security controls and audit trails.
- Cost: the pricing model and the total cost of ownership over several years.

4. Comparison of Platforms

Platform	Type	Strength	Limitation	Typical User
Zoho Creator	Low-code	Forms, workflows, reports; Deluge scripting; Zoho ecosystem	Advanced customisation needs scripting	Small and medium businesses
Microsoft Power Apps	Low-code	Deep Microsoft 365 and Azure integration	Licensing can be complex	Enterprises on the Microsoft stack
Google AppSheet	No-code	Builds apps quickly from spreadsheets and databases	Complex logic is limited	Teams using Google Workspace
Airtable	No-code	Database-style base with views and interfaces	Costs rise with heavy usage	Operations and content teams
Bubble	No-code	Full web application with custom logic	Learning curve for advanced workflows	Startups and product prototypes
OutSystems	Low-code	Enterprise scale and strong governance	Higher cost and steeper learning	Large enterprises

The comparison is based on the public positioning and typical features of each platform. Pricing, features and vendor offerings change over time, so the figures should be checked on each vendor's current website before a purchase decision.

5. Analysis

For a college or small business that needs forms, approvals and reports with moderate customisation, Zoho Creator offers a balanced choice. It combines a visual builder with a scripting language and integrates with other business tools in the Zoho family. For organisations already committed to one vendor's ecosystem, the native platform is usually the strongest choice, because identity, data and licensing are already in place. Platforms such as OutSystems are better suited where governance, performance at scale and strict architecture standards matter more than speed of first delivery.

No-code platforms are attractive for prototypes and departmental tools, but their limits become visible when the business needs complex logic, high transaction volumes or detailed audit controls. A common path is to start with a no-code or low-code tool and move the most critical parts to custom code when the application matures.

6. Result and Conclusion

No single platform is best for every situation. The choice depends on the complexity of the application, the existing technology stack, the skills of the team, the required level of control and the total cost of ownership. The comparison shows that low-code platforms offer more flexibility, while no-code platforms offer faster and simpler delivery for common business needs.